4.3 Breaking with Britain

Congress has always had a difficult job, making decisions that will impact a large number of people. In 1775, the Second Continental Congress faced a hard choice: pursue peace or prepare for war.

MAIN IDEA The Second Continental Congress made one last attempt to make peace with Britain, but fighting continued and public opinion moved toward declaring independence.

PEACE REJECTED

During the summer of 1775, the Continental Congress made moves toward both peace and war. In an attempt to restore peace with Britain, delegates sent the king a petition. They asked him to resolve the conflict between the colonies and Parliament. Instead, he proclaimed that the colonies were in "an open and avowed rebellion."

At the same time, Congress sent an army north to invade Canada and take on the British forces there. This proved to be a poor decision. The Canada campaign was long, bloody, and unsuccessful. British troops successfully pushed the colonial army back into New York.

In December 1775, Parliament decided to punish the colonies by cutting off all trade. Then in January 1776, King George signed a treaty with Germany that allowed him to hire more than 20,000 German soldiers and send them to the colonies. These soldiers for hire were known as **Hessians**, and they had a reputation as fierce fighters. For many Americans, these actions proved that the British government intended to crush the colonies both militarily and economically, at any cost.

TIME TO PART

Meanwhile, the colonial army was meeting with greater success in Boston. George Washington had arrived there during the summer of 1775, determined to drive the British from the city. The following winter, he sent troops to drag the heavy guns from Fort Ticonderoga and install them on high ground overlooking Boston. In the spring of 1776, under the threat of the looming artillery, the British withdrew from the city. They sailed north to Canada in preparation for an eventual invasion of New York City. More than a thousand Loyalists left with the British because they feared they would not be safe from angry Patriots if they stayed in Boston.

Alarmed by the colonists' show of force in Boston, the British government sent a massive force to put down the revolt. Nearly 400 ships set sail from England carrying 32,000 troops, including at least 12,000 Hessians. The soldiers would join the British troops already gathering in Canada for an attack on New York City. The warships would attack seaports and disrupt colonial shipping.



Hessian miter cap

National Museum of American History
Washington, D.C.

This hat, called a miter cap, was worn by a Hessian infantry soldier from the Fusilier Regiment, which served under the British Army during the American Revolution. The cap has a cloth body covered with a brass cap plate and is stamped with a Hessian lion.

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Printing *Common Sense*

Colonial printers working on printing presses similar to the one shown here created publications one page at a time. They carefully folded paper onto set and inked letters and then used a lever to press the images and words onto the page.

Thousands of copies of *Common Sense* were printed, sold, and read aloud in meeting rooms and inns throughout the colonies. Because it was originally anonymous, many initially attributed *Common Sense* to Ben Franklin. As you have read, before he was a scientist and revolutionary, Ben Franklin was a printer and publisher in Philadelphia. He even owned his own printing press, so it is not a surprise that some would think he published *Common Sense*.

Printing Press



In January 1776, **Thomas Paine** published a pamphlet called *Common Sense* to argue the case for independence. In the pamphlet, Paine made several practical arguments for independence. He claimed that France and Spain would only aid the colonies if they broke with Britain. He also pointed out that European countries would continue to purchase American exports if the colonies declared independence. "'Tis time to part," he urged his readers. As the eventful year unfolded, more and more Americans agreed with him.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Which events in 1775 and 1776 led the colonies toward independence?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** Why did the British government respond with overwhelming force to events in North America, and what was the colonial response?
3. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What was Thomas Paine's principal argument in favor of independence?

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